

Project 4 – Stakeholder Engagement and Mini-Engagement Plan

Project: Intelligent Complaint Classification Using Localized Transformer Architectures

Team: Team Stanley

Draft prepared as individual team input for review

1. Selected Stakeholder Groups

1. Consumers and community members
2. Employees and customer-service/complaint-handling staff

2. What Matters Most to the Stakeholders – 100 Words

Consumers and community members care most about privacy, accurate complaint classification, and timely responses. They need assurance that personal information contained in complaints is protected and that their concerns will not be ignored or incorrectly routed. Employees, meanwhile, are concerned with reducing repetitive workload while preserving fair working conditions, meaningful roles, and appropriate human oversight. They also care about classification accuracy because incorrect routing can increase workload and delay resolution. Both groups therefore have a strong interest in accuracy, privacy, fairness, and effective complaint handling. Their interests differ mainly in emphasis: consumers focus on the quality and safety of the service they receive, while employees also consider how the system affects their work.

3. Potential Harms and Potential Benefits

Consumers and Community Members

Potential harms

- Incorrect classification or routing could delay the handling of a complaint.
- Language barriers could affect people whose complaints contain slang, code-switching, Nigerian Pidgin, or indigenous-language expressions that are poorly represented in the data.
- Some complaint types or experiences may be underrepresented or excluded from the model's categories.
- Mishandling complaint data could create privacy risks.
- Consumers may become frustrated if they have to repeatedly explain a complaint because of incorrect automated classification.
- Excessive reliance on automation could reduce opportunities for consumers to have unusual or complex complaints reviewed by a person.

Potential benefits

- Faster classification and routing could lead to quicker responses.
- More consistent classification could reduce avoidable delays and transfers.
- The system could help identify recurring complaint patterns and areas where services need improvement.
- Future inclusion of African linguistic varieties could make complaint systems more accessible to a wider population.
- Better routing could help organizations allocate resources to the complaints and issues that require particular attention.

Employees and Customer-Service Staff

Potential harms

- Routine complaint-classification roles could be reduced or changed as automation is introduced.
- Employees who remain may experience increased pressure if they have to handle more complex cases without adequate support.
- Incorrect classifications could create additional work rather than reducing workload.
- Employees' practical expertise could be undervalued if the model is treated as automatically correct.
- Poorly designed automation could reduce job satisfaction or make complaint handling more frustrating.
- Language or category limitations could result in employees having to correct the same types of model errors repeatedly.

Potential benefits

- Less time spent on repetitive classification and initial sorting.
- Faster routing of complaints to appropriate teams.
- More time for employees to focus on complex cases requiring human judgement and empathy.
- Better allocation of staff and organizational resources.
- Identification of recurring complaint patterns that can help organizations improve services.
- Creation of new specialized roles involving model monitoring, error analysis, maintenance, evaluation, and improvement.

4. Engagement Methods

Consumers and Community Members

Chosen method: Distributed Dialogue

The Action Catalogue describes Distributed Dialogue as an approach that develops ongoing discussions around a topic and creates multiple opportunities for citizens and stakeholders to participate. It can involve dialogue events across different locations and through different forms of media. The method aims to bring a range of experiences and perspectives into discussions and connect the outcomes to decision-making.

Employees and Customer-Service Staff

Chosen method: Participatory Design

The Action Catalogue describes Participatory Design as beginning with consultation and continuing through an interactive design process that includes field testing with users of the technology. It can include workshops, consultation, design workbooks, and other collaborative activities. The method is therefore suitable for involving employees in the development and testing of an AI-assisted complaint-classification system.

5. Why These Methods Fit the Stakeholders

A. Consumers and Community Members – Distributed Dialogue

Distributed Dialogue is an appropriate engagement method for consumers and community members because our project is intended to influence how people's complaints are understood, classified, and routed. Consumers are therefore not simply sources of complaint data; they are people who may be directly affected by the decisions and processes supported by the model. Their experiences can reveal concerns that may not be visible from the dataset alone, particularly around privacy, accuracy, trust, fairness, language, and the consequences of incorrect complaint routing.

The Action Catalogue explains that Distributed Dialogue is based on the idea that complex issues require conversations in different spaces and that multiple entry points can allow more citizens and stakeholders to

participate meaningfully. It also emphasizes the importance of connecting these conversations back to decision-making. This is relevant to our project because consumer perspectives should influence how we think about the model rather than being collected simply as opinions after development has finished.

For example, different consumers may have different priorities. Some may place privacy above all else and want strong assurance that personal information in complaint narratives will not be exposed or unnecessarily reused. Others may prioritize speed and want their complaints routed to the correct department as quickly as possible. Some may be more concerned about whether an automated system can understand the way they naturally communicate, particularly when complaints contain slang, abbreviations, code-switching, Nigerian Pidgin, or indigenous-language expressions. Distributed Dialogue can create space for these different perspectives to be discussed rather than assuming that all consumers have identical needs.

The engagement could involve several forms of dialogue, such as facilitated discussions with community groups, online discussions, and smaller local conversations. This would also allow us to reach people with different experiences rather than relying on one convenient group of participants. Participants could discuss examples of complaint-handling experiences and respond to possible uses of automated classification. They could identify what they would consider an unacceptable error, what information they would expect to remain private, and when they would expect human involvement.

This method also has limitations that need to be considered. The Action Catalogue notes that data collected through distributed activities can be inconsistent, that creating representative groups is challenging, and that inclusiveness and transparency can be difficult to guarantee. These weaknesses are particularly important for our project because a small or unrepresentative group could cause us to design around the experiences of only certain consumers. We would therefore need to deliberately seek diverse perspectives and use a consistent way of recording and analyzing feedback.

The most important reason for choosing Distributed Dialogue is that it can help ensure the project responds to the people affected by complaint-classification systems. Consumer feedback could influence privacy safeguards, the types of language and communication styles considered during future data collection, the importance assigned to different classification errors, and the circumstances in which automated predictions should be reviewed by a human. In this way, engagement can contribute to making the system more accurate, responsible, inclusive, and responsive to real consumer needs.

B. Employees and Customer-Service Staff – Participatory Design

Participatory Design is an appropriate engagement method for employees and customer-service staff because these stakeholders have direct experience with the process our project aims to improve: receiving, understanding, classifying, and routing consumer complaints. According to the Action Catalogue, Participatory Design begins with consultation and continues into an interactive design process that includes field testing with users of the developed technology. It can also involve workshops, consultation, and design workbooks. This approach is relevant to our project because employees should not only be asked whether they support an AI complaint-classification system; they should have opportunities to contribute to how the system is designed and tested.

Customer-service employees can provide practical knowledge that may not be visible in the dataset alone. For example, they may know which complaint categories are frequently confused, which complaints require additional context, and which cases should be escalated to a human rather than handled automatically. They can also identify situations where a classification that appears reasonable to a model may be inappropriate in an actual customer-service setting. Including this knowledge during the design process could help us develop a system that supports employees rather than simply replacing part of their existing workflow.

Consultation and workshops could initially be used to understand employees' experiences with complaint handling, including repetitive tasks, common sources of delay, difficult cases, and the consequences of incorrect routing. Employees could then participate in an interactive design process where possible model outputs and proposed workflows are reviewed. Their feedback could help determine how classifications should be presented, when confidence is too low for automated routing, and when human review should be required. Field testing would provide another opportunity to observe whether the system actually reduces repetitive work or unintentionally creates additional work through incorrect or unclear classifications.

Participatory Design is also suitable because the Action Catalogue identifies employees and users among the actors who can be involved in the method. Its strengths include being strongly grounded in the needs and experiences of participants, while its weakness is that co-creation requires careful listening, sensitivity, and effective facilitation. These considerations are important for our project because employees may have legitimate concerns about job security, changes to their responsibilities, workload, and whether their expertise will still be valued. Their concerns should therefore be treated as part of the design problem rather than as resistance to technology.

The engagement could ultimately influence both the model and its surrounding workflow. Employee feedback could inform the selection and representation of complaint categories, identify difficult or ambiguous examples for testing, and establish situations requiring human intervention. It could also influence evaluation criteria by highlighting errors that have greater consequences in real complaint-handling situations. In this way, Participatory Design would make employees active contributors to developing a system that is more accurate, practical, responsible, and useful in real-world complaint handling.

6. How the Engagement Methods Could Influence Dataset and Model Design – 100 Words

Engagement could directly influence which complaints and linguistic patterns are represented in future datasets, especially those involving slang, code-switching, Nigerian Pidgin, indigenous languages, and difficult or ambiguous cases. Consumer feedback could identify privacy expectations, missing complaint experiences, and errors that would have serious consequences for users. Employee participation could identify commonly confused categories, cases requiring human review, and workflow problems caused by incorrect predictions. These findings could guide data collection, category design, annotation rules, model evaluation, and human-escalation thresholds. Feedback could also help us identify underrepresented groups and test whether the model performs consistently across different forms of complaint expression and stakeholder needs.

Draft Note for Team Review

This is my initial contribution to Project 4. The stakeholder groups, engagement methods, risks, benefits, and proposed influence on the dataset/model are intended as a draft for team discussion. Jane can review the choices, add her own perspective, and suggest changes before we treat the plan as a final team submission.